

A black and white photograph of a man with a serious expression, looking slightly off-camera. He is wearing a light-colored, possibly white, jacket over a collared shirt. He is holding a small, fluffy lamb in his arms. The background is a dark, rocky beach with waves crashing against the shore to the left. The overall mood is somber and contemplative.

UNIVERSE25

a film by Richard Melkonian

**An angel from the
future is sent to
Earth on a
holy mission:**

**find the saint
the sacrificial lamb
and write a scroll**

Film Information

Original / English Title : Universe25

Countries of Production: United Kingdom, Romania

Duration: 84 Minutes

Festival Screenings (to date)

World Premiere Slamdance 2025

Technical Details

Screening Material: DCP 2K

Shooting Format: 16mm Celluloid Kodak

Sound: 5.1 surround

Speed: 24FPS

Colour and Black & White

English Language and Romanian (With English Subtitles)

Online Teaser Link

<https://vimeo.com/784758088>

DAN SOCIU ALEX BOGDAN **GIACOMO GEX** TANIA KHAN ANA GURAN



ENTROPY FILMS PRESENTS

GIACOMO GEX DAN SOCIU ALEX BOGDAN ANA GURAN TANIA KHAN AND MARIA FORRESTER

PRODUCTION DESIGN BY ELODIE CHIPER COSTUME DESIGNER ELODIE CHIPER MUSIC BY RICHARD MELKONIAN

EDITED BY TOMMASO GALLONE DIRECTOR OF PHOTOGRAPHY JUANJO SALAZAR GIACOMO GEX AND FRASER RIGG

PRODUCED BY RICHARD MELKONIAN AND GIACOMO GEX

STORY BY DAN SOCIU RICHARD MELKONIAN GIACOMO GEX

WRITTEN BY RICHARD MELKONIAN SCREENPLAY BY RICHARD MELKONIAN DIRECTED BY RICHARD MELKONIAN

Synopsis

A young postman is tasked with sorting out lost post. Upon reading one opened letter, written by an author who claims to be an Angel from the future, we see the events narrated by the author, the fallen angel Mott.

Mott tells his story, where he is from and his holy mission. Mott receives messages from an unknown entity via a series of phone calls, that tell him he must do three things before the next sabbath, when the world will end.

1. Find the saint, he knows not that he is holy
2. Find the sacrificial lamb and offer its blood for the sacrament.
3. Write a scroll and record in it everything that he sees.

As Mott attempts to fulfil his master's wishes he becomes disillusioned with his quest and wishes to become a human, forfeiting his immortality.

Questions arise about the validity of the author's tale and the truth of his identity. In the end it is up to the young post man to get Mott's message to its intended destination ...









Director's Statement

My vision for the film stems from the initial creative impulse that started this project—visual, musical, and rhythmic. I wanted Universe25 to feel like reading the writings or sketches from a journal you might stumble upon by the Thames on a rainy winter's day, or the scattered ramblings of an unknown and questionable author. I wanted the film to feel both poetic and abrupt, yet also elusive and jaunty. My primary goal was to conjure an original mood.

The story, plot, and characters that would eventually populate Universe25 came later. Specific tonal anchors guided me throughout the process.

I was particularly drawn to creating a film that is explicitly polystylistic. Inspired by the work of composers Luciano Berio and Alfred Schnittke, as well as the poet Fernando Pessoa, I wanted style and tone to become subjects of deliberate manipulation, quotation, and play.

I never had a complete screenplay for this film. Instead, I wrote and developed material as we shot. This approach, inspired by documentary filmmaking, allowed the rushes to inform what I wrote next. I believe this process yielded story material that I could never have written in advance. This method was influenced by devised theatre and the work of filmmakers like Mike Leigh and Wong Kar Wai.

I also had the opportunity to edit scenes and write music while we were still shooting, which was incredibly stimulating. Post-production and production collided, and all conventional order dissolved, allowing a free and organic creative process to unfold. This process spanned over four years—it was difficult to bring it to a close, as it felt like it could continue infinitely. The first scene was shot in November 2021, and the final scene in February 2024.

It's important for me to emphasize that I consider this film a musical drama. Composing the music for Universe25 was an essential part of the process; the marriage of music, image, and text is ultimately why I am drawn to cinema as an expressive medium. During production, I sketched numerous musical ideas, but in the end, I discarded all of them and composed the entire score in a four-week frenzy. The final score, written for a string quartet, was crafted to bring the film's emotional landscape to life.

I hope the audience allows themselves to be whisked away by the movie, immersing themselves in Mott's adventure as he navigates this strange world—the underbelly of urban life, the follies of love, and the macabre reality of mortality. Making this film has been an incredible journey of creative discovery, and I am thrilled to finally share it with the world.



Richard Melkonian

Writer, Director, Composer & Producer

Richard Melkonian is an award-winning London based Armenian-British composer and director who works across concert music, opera, theatre, film and performance art. In 2019 he was one of the Old Vic 12 and finished his MA in Opera Making at Guildhall School for Music & Drama in association with the Royal Opera House. His music investigates his dual heritage, blending the rich Armenian folk and liturgical tradition with a contemporary and British sensibility.

Richard's primary practice is a narrative filmmaker that use his own classical scores. His debut feature length film *Universe25* is set to premiere at Slamdance 2025 in LA.

His last film Fourteen, starring Babirye Bukilwa and Ben Mushumani, premiere at Palm Springs 2020. In 2017, his first film November, starring Andre Flynn, was nominated for best experimental short at Blow Up ArtHouse Festival, Chicago.

In 2018, his commission by Mahogany Group to write new operatic work, The Finding, with libretto by Zoe Palmer was performed at the Institute of Contemporary Arts, London. In 2015, he won the Mary Ryan Award for composition and was also a finalist for the AGBU Sayat Nova Competition where his piece Andastan was performed at Symphony Space, New York. He has written scores for several films including Filip Firlej's award-winning If It Be Love, premiered at the Raindance Film Festival, London 2015, Emma Swinton's Isabella, and Aaron Leaman's documentary Looking for Infinity: El Camino.

For theatre, he was Musical Director at The National Theatre, Cardiff for 'Hail, Cremation! directed by Adele Thomas in 2020. He composed original music for the world premiere of Arthur Miller's No Villain at Trafalgar Studios in 2016, directed by Sean Turner. He has collaborated with Arab writers Ahmed Masoud as well as Sevan K. Greene on several plays including Nahda, part of Shubbak festival for contemporary Arab arts and literature. As a performance artist, he has performed at the Chalton Gallery and for London's Art Night at Arnold Circus. Richard also works as a music producer and has collaborated with breakthrough artist Jordan Rakei on their duo project Kwalia with their first EP Pursuit soaring to the top of Spotify's New Releases chart and playlists. His undergraduate degree and Masters in Classical Composition at the Guildhall was made possible by the Guildhall Scholarship Trust. Alongside composition, Richard also studied Jazz Piano with Barry Green.



Giacomo Gex

Lead Actor, Co-Producer and Cinematographer (additional photography)

Giacomo Gex is a British and French actor and director. Born in London, raised in the Sinai desert of Egypt and the Mediterranean island of Ibiza in Spain. At 13 after seeing The Matrix for the first time he became completely absorbed and consumed by cinema. During his teenage years he starred yearly as the lead in his school plays and the gift of a small camcorder spawned his obsession with the art of visual storytelling. After finishing school he attended the Lee Strasberg Theatre and Film Institute in Los Angeles and later New York City. It was there that he began to learn his craft as an actor on stage under such acclaimed teachers as Lola Cohen and Robert Ellerman. As a filmmaker he also made a series of short films and in 2015, Repoman, his short documentary premiered at the renowned Sheffield DocFest as well as the Slamdance Film Festival.

Since moving back to London in 2020 he was selected for his first role in a feature film, Miss Willoughby and the Haunted Bookshop playing a younger version of, and starring alongside, Kelsey Grammer known for such TV shows as Frasier. Towards the end of 2021 Giacomo began work behind the camera on his latest feature film Universe25 for director Richard Melkonian and would soon move in front of the camera playing the lead role as Mott the angel. Giacomo is currently writing his first feature film script set in the Sinai desert where he grew up and has just completed his debut feature documentary that has been in the making for over 7 years and set to hold its world premiere at the Thessaloniki International Documentary Festival in March 2025.



Elodie Chiper

Production Designer, Costume Designer and Co-Producer

Elodie Chiper is a theatre and film production & costume designer based in London. She graduated in 2020 from The Royal Central School of Speech and Drama London from MFA Scenography. She did her BA in in theatre and film set&costume design at The National University of Theatre and Film "I.L. Caragiale" in Bucharest, Romania. In 2021 she was shortlisted for the prestigious The Linbury Prize for Stage and Costume Design for theatre and performance (in partnership with The National Theatre London). She has worked as an Assistant Designer for Hackney Empire, Shotgun Carousel, English Touring Opera, National Theatre of Catalonia, Stuttgart State Opera, collaborated closely with coreographer Yoann Bourgeois as a storyboard artist and worked as a production & costume designer on various short & feature films. She has also been working as an illustrator & graphic artist, collaborating with film magazines such as Films in Frame and publishing houses as Casa de Editura Max Blecher.

Her illustrations also appeared in a special number in the renowned Romanian cultural magazine Steaua and Scena9, accompanying the poems of award winning poet Radu Niteanu. In 2021 she was commissioned by Independent Theatre Timisoara to create an online comic book based on a new writing text by Andrei Ursu. Her own video work and interest for moving image has been shown at film festivals such as Short to the Point Bucharest Experimental film festival and Venice International Film Festival. In 2021 she collaborated with Latvian-Russian poet Sergej Timofeev, member of Orbita, a creative collective of Russian poets and artists and musician Stephane Argillet Stereovoid creating a video poem for one of his poems which was screened at The Brasov European Poetry Biennale.



Juanjo L. Salazar

Director of Photography

Juanjo L. Salazar is a Colombian-born cinematographer currently based in London and represented by United Talent Agency.

His passion for filmmaking began at a young age when he started experimenting with video cameras, initially filming short home videos and later shooting skate videos for his local skate shop.

While pursuing a BA in Telecommunications Engineering at the Polytechnic University of Barcelona, he developed an interest in camera engineering, which merged his technical and creative backgrounds. After graduating as an engineer and completing an internship at Service Vision in Barcelona, he discovered that cinematography was his true calling.

Since then, he has worked to maintain a diverse portfolio, shifting between narrative, commercial, documentary, music video, and experimental projects. Although primarily focused on short-form work, his collaboration with Richard Melkonian on Universe25 marked a significant step toward longer-format storytelling.



Main Cast

Mott / Tom - Giacomo Gex

Andre - Dan Sociu

Jocasta - Tania Khan

Jacob (Young Postman) - Jacob Meadows

Chris (Boss Postman) - Alec Christie

Darius - Alex Bogdan

Perriot - Ana-Maria Guran

Alina - Maria Forrester

Main Creative Credits

Director/Writer/ Composer - Richard Melkonian

Director of Photographer - Juanjo L. Salazar

Production Design & Costume Designer - Elodie Chiper

Editor - Tomasso Gallone

Sound Designer - Srdjan Krupjel

Colourist - Darren Rae

1st Assistant Director - Josh Jacobs

1st Assistant Camera Bernat - Bonaventura

Film Processed and Scanned at **Cinelab UK**

UNIVERSE25

an Entropy Films Production

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**Produced by Richard Melkonian
Co-Producer Giacomo Gex
Co-Producer Elodie Chiper**

